Art Deco

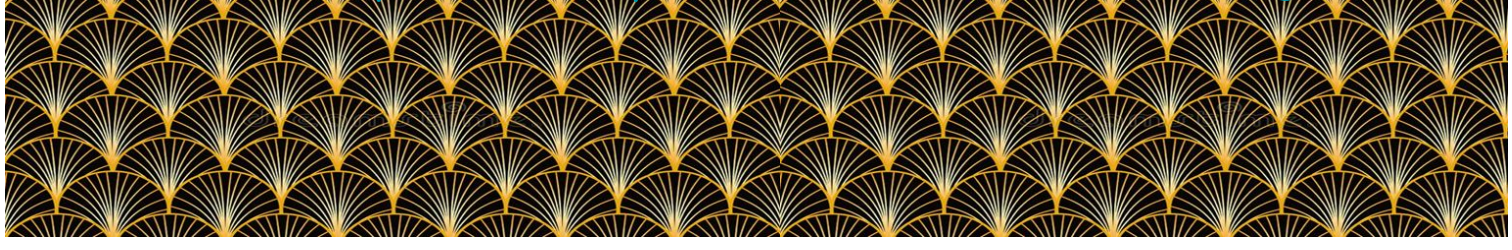


Eileen Gray

1900 - 1939

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gTaEJ92lFGk





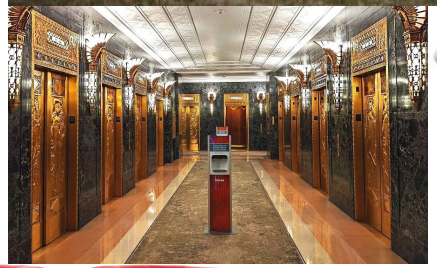
ACTIVITY 1 - Starter: Record your thoughts… **SEE, THINK, WONDER**







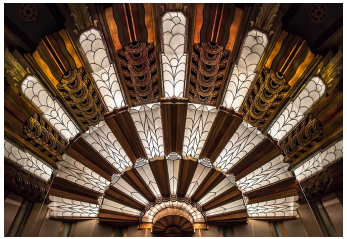












"Based on what you have seen, how would we define the aesthetic language of Art Deco?"

Record your thoughts… **SEE, THINK, WONDER**

Individually record your observations:

'What do I see?',
'What do I think about this?',
'What does it make me wonder?'.
"Why might symmetry have been so important to designers of this period?
What message does it convey?"

Prompt: love of bold, streamlined geometric shapes, the embrace of luxurious materials and rich colors, a commitment to symmetry and balance

USEFUL Link:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fkuy3j7C1us

Key Principles on Arts Deco

Art Deco's core principles include a love of bold, streamlined geometric shapes, the embrace of luxurious materials and rich colors, a commitment to symmetry and balance, and a reflection of the modernity and industrial progress of its time, often featuring decorative elements like zigzags, sunbursts, and machine-age motifs. The style aimed for sophisticated, glamorous, and elegant designs that showcased innovation and craftsmanship.

Key principles:

Geometric Forms

A central feature is the use of bold, geometric shapes, including zigzags, chevrons, sunbursts, and stepped forms, often arranged in symmetrical and balanced compositions.

Luxurious Materials

The style incorporates high-quality, sometimes exotic, materials such as gold, chrome, stainless steel, marble, and fine woods to create a sense of opulence and glamour.

Symmetry and Precision

Art Deco design adheres to symmetry and meticulous arrangement, reflecting a desire for order, balance, and harmonious aesthetics.

Modernity and Industrialization

Influenced by the industrial revolution and technological advancement, the style incorporates streamlined forms, machine motifs, and a modern, futuristic aesthetic.

Bold Colors and Ornamentation

Art Deco is known for vibrant, contrasting colors and a profusion of ornamentation that expresses sophistication and visual richness.

Elegant and Glamorous Aesthetic

Overall, Art Deco aims to convey a sense of refined elegance, sophisticated luxury, and a forward-looking, dynamic beauty.

History Facts on Arts Deco Movement

Art Deco emerged in the early 20th century, gaining prominence after World War I, and flourished globally from the 1920s to the 1930s, peaking during the Roaring Twenties before declining with the Great Depression and World War II. The style, characterized by geometric shapes, bold colors, and luxurious materials, was named in 1968 and reflects a blend of traditional and modern influences.

Key Dates & Periods

- **Origins**: The style began in France in the early 1900s and was showcased internationally at the 1925 Exposition des Arts Décoratifs.
- **Flourishing Period**: Art Deco achieved widespread popularity between the 1920s and the outbreak of World War II in 1939.
- **Peak Popularity**: The Roaring Twenties saw the zenith of the Art Deco movement.
- **Decline**: The Great Depression and the start of World War II led to a decline in Art Deco's popularity in the 1930s.
- **Naming**: The style's current name, "Art Deco," was coined in 1968 during a period of scholarly interest.

Key Characteristics

- **Geometric Aesthetic**: Emphasizes streamlined, symmetrical, and geometric forms, a shift from earlier ornate styles.
- **Modern Influences**: Incorporates elements from Cubism, Futurism, and Constructivism, celebrating the Machine Age.
- **Luxurious Materials**: Features bold colors and luxurious materials, often combining them with sleek, modern lines.
- **Global Reach**: A truly international design movement that spread across Europe and the United States.

Key Principles of Eileen Gray

User-Centric and Human-Focused Design

Human Needs: Gray's work was built around understanding and fulfilling human needs, focusing on comfort and ergonomics.

Adaptability and Multi-Purpose Design: Her fluid approach to product design favored multi-purpose and space-efficient solutions that could adapt to individual users' routines and spatially constrained settings.

Design for the User, Not Trends: She believed in designing for individuals' habits and needs rather than for fleeting trends, resulting in more successful and long-lasting products

Innovative Use of Materials

Experimental Materials: Gray was a pioneer in her use of materials, incorporating elements like tubular steel, glass, chrome, and lacquer into her designs.

Combining Traditional and Modern Techniques: She radicalized traditional crafts, such as lacquer, by fusing them with modern principles and new materials to create unique textures and finishes.

Integration of Function and Form

Artistic Interpretation of Function: While embracing modernism, Gray interpreted functionality in an artistic way, contrasting with the more standardized approaches of some contemporaries.

Furniture and Architecture as One: She believed that furniture and architecture were intrinsically linked, with pieces often designed specifically for the rooms they would inhabit

Key Principles of Eileen Gray... CONTINUED

Aesthetic Purity and Personal Vision

Modernist Principles with a Personal Touch: Gray embodied modernism's emphasis on simplicity, functionality, and honest materials, but combined it with her own individual artistic expression and an intuitive sense of space and proportion.

Minimalist Elegance: Her aesthetic favored clean lines, geometric shapes, and a deliberate absence of ornamentation, creating elegant and uncomplicated designs.

Sensual and Glamorous Qualities: Despite the minimalism, Gray's work often retained a sensual quality, evident in the high-gloss finishes of her lacquer screens and her overall approach to materials and textures.





ACTIVITY 2 - The Eames of Art Deco? Analyzing Eileen Gray's ...

Charles Eames and **Ray Eames** were an American married couple of industrial designers who made significant historical contributions to the development of modern architecture and furniture.



Roquebrune house





Transat chair





Bibendum chair



Adjustable Table E 1027

"Where is the influence of Art Deco most evident in her work? What elements appear unique or different?"

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=EC7MIfMSz_s

Activity 3: Application and Justification

Analyse the radio on on the separate google slide, recording your **judgments based on the characteristics of Art Deco** and the specific **interpretations of Eileen Gray** you have studied.



Prompt:

"How can you use the design vocabulary of Art Deco, particularly as understood through Eileen Gray's practice, to analyze this new object?"

Group Work:

In pairs, discuss your analyses. You must justify your claims using specific evidence from the object and your notes from the previous activities.

"What specific elements make you say this is 'Art Deco,' and how does that element relate to what we learned about Eileen Gray's approach?"

Assessment/Exit Ticket





Choose one of the following two objects: **a vintage streamlined locomotive from the 1930s** or **a modern piece of furniture that claims to be "inspired by Art Deco."**

Write a paragraph evaluating the object's design. In your evaluation, you must:
a) identify at least two key characteristics of the Art Deco movement present in the object, and
b) discuss how Eileen Gray's unique design approach to materials, form, or function might be either reflected in or absent from the object. Justify your points with specific examples from the object's design.

Exemplar Response: A strong response will accurately identify two or more characteristics, such as symmetry, geometric patterns, or streamlined forms, and provide specific evidence from the object to support this claim. It will then demonstrate an understanding of Eileen Gray's unique contribution by connecting the object's design to her use of unexpected materials (e.g., chrome, lacquer), her emphasis on movable or adjustable parts, or her blend of aesthetic and functional concerns. The response will justify its claims with reasoned evaluations rather than simple statements of fact, using phrases like "The use of... is a direct echo of..." or "Unlike Gray's approach, the object's design prioritizes... over..."